C2 Listening

Hearing the speaker's attitude

Work out what a speaker really thinks from hedges, contrasts and loaded words in spoken English.

In C2 listening tasks the answer is rarely stated directly. Speakers soften criticism, praise with reservations and change direction mid-sentence. The words around the opinion tell you more than the opinion itself.

Signal	Example	What it usually means
Concession then contrast	*It's beautifully shot, but…*	The real view comes after *but*.
Hedging	*I'm not entirely convinced…*	Polite disagreement.
Faint praise	*It's perfectly competent.*	Disappointed.
Loaded words	*a bloated script, a daring choice*	Strong negative or positive judgement.

Listen

Count the buts. Mark each *but*, *though* and *just don't*. The sentence after the last one is often the speaker's final view.

Common mistake. Choosing the answer that repeats the speaker's words. *Beautifully shot* is said, but the overall opinion is mixed to negative.

Practice

1. What does the speaker praise without reservation?
2. What does *does what he can with the material* suggest about the script?
3. What does *rather more relaxed* really mean?
4. How does the speaker expect audiences to react to the ending?

5. Overall, the speaker's view is: (a) enthusiastic (b) mixed, leaning negative (c) completely negative

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Transcript

So, the new film. Look, it's beautifully shot, there's no denying that, and the lead actor does what he can with the material. But I'm not entirely convinced the director knew what story she wanted to tell. The first hour is gripping; the second is, shall we say, rather more relaxed. And the ending, which I won't spoil, is a daring choice that I suspect will divide audiences. Would I recommend it? For the photography alone, possibly. Just don't expect to remember much of the plot on the way home.

Answers

1. The photography (it is beautifully shot).
2. That the script is weak; the actor is not to blame.
3. Slow or boring (understatement).
4. Some will like it and some will not; it will divide audiences.
5. (b) mixed, leaning negative